

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Ms Victoria France

Address: 1 Sandringham Court 11 Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6NG

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer objects to the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I wish to submit an objection to the proposed development at the former ambulance station site on the grounds of clarity of use, potential intensification of activity, and the resulting impact on traffic, parking, residential amenity, and inclusive community access.

When I attended the Open Day, the proposal was presented primarily as a community centre with allocated times for prayer. Based on this, I understood that the community centre would operate in a similar way to the community centre I currently attend, where rooms are hired out for small classes and activities typically involving around four or five people per session, usually generating only two or three cars at a time. On that basis, I viewed the proposal positively and supported the idea of a genuine community hub. My understanding at the time was that community use would form the principal function of the building, with prayer use incorporated alongside it.

However, following discussions within the community and my own research regarding BASMA, I have become concerned that there will be significantly larger numbers of people attending activities and prayers than I had originally understood. I acknowledge that regular prayer use, including larger Friday prayers, was discussed at the Open Day; however, while it was indicated that most attendees would walk from surrounding streets, the locations of people submitting supporting comments indicate that many attendees live outside the immediate local area and will therefore be travelling to the site by car, increasing car movements and parking demand beyond what would normally be expected of a neighbourhood community facility.

There is also concern that the building's future use may evolve to operate primarily as a mosque and place of worship rather than remaining a mixed-use community facility. This distinction is

important from a planning perspective because differing primary uses can generate materially different patterns and intensities of activity.

The surrounding area already experiences significant congestion during school drop-off and collection periods, and any increase in concentrated attendance could exacerbate existing traffic pressures, parking demand, and associated disturbance within what is otherwise a quiet residential environment. In addition, experience from other mixed-use applications indicates that community-use elements can diminish over time once permission for a place of worship has been established. While this may not be the applicant's intention, planning decisions should consider long-term operational outcomes as well as initial proposals, and it is therefore important that the intended primary use, anticipated attendance levels, traffic impacts, and the balance between community and worship use are clearly defined and, where necessary, secured through appropriate planning conditions to prevent future intensification beyond what has currently been presented to residents.

I would also ask the Council to consider how equal and inclusive access to the proposed community facilities will be ensured, particularly with regard to women's participation. My understanding from discussions with individuals familiar with the organisation, together with publicly available material such as event photographs, is that participation in some existing activities appears to be predominantly male. While I fully respect religious practice, a development described and supported as a community facility should demonstrably serve the whole local community on an equal basis. It is therefore important that women have meaningful, regular, and equivalent access to community spaces and activities, and that the community-use element operates in a genuinely inclusive manner consistent with equality expectations for publicly accessible community facilities.